

Antipassive constructions: Universals and language description

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This paper discusses antipassive universals, and as a prerequisite for this, the definition of the term *antipassive*. I suggest that antipassive constructions are best seen as strategies (and not defined functionally), and are best treated as defined in a way that is parallel to the definition of passive constructions. I emphasize that language-particular description is only indirectly related to comparison: It can profit from it via transparency and inspiration, but comparative grammar is primarily concerned with finding universals and (ultimately) their explanations.

1. Overview

This paper revisits universals of antipassive constructions, and discusses the way the term *antipassive* is defined (in §2 and §5). I discuss antipassive constructions such as those in (1b) (from Warrongo, a Pama-Nyungan language of Australia), and I suggest that they should be defined in a way that is parallel to the definition of passives (as in 2b).

(1) Warrongo antipassive voice alternation (Tsunoda 2011: 428)

a. *Bama-nggo gamo-Ø yangga-n.*

man-ERG water-ABS search-NF

‘The man looked for water.’

b. *Bama-Ø gamo-wu yangga-gali-n.*

man-ABS water-DAT search-ANTP-NF

‘The man looked for water.’ (antipassive construction)

(2) Turkish passive voice alternation

a. *Musa ev-i temizle-di.*

Musa house-ACC clean-PST

‘Musa cleaned the house.’

b. *Ev temizle-n-di.*

house clean-PASS-PST

‘The house was cleaned.’ (passive construction)

Antipassive universals have not been as prominent in the literature as passive universals (Haspelmath 2026b), but I will discuss three universals that have been present in the literature (though not normally called “universals”) (§3). Then I will discuss the mirror-image relationship between antipassive and passive constructions (§4), before offering further discussion of the definition of *antipassive* (§5). Next, §6 makes a few tentative proposals for explaining the universals. Finally, in §7 I highlight the importance of describing each language and each construction in its own terms, implying that a

general-comparative term such as *antipassive* is useful for language describers primarily for the purpose of inspiration and transparency: Knowledge of universals is relevant only for general-theoretical linguistics, not for describing or analyzing particular languages. The paper ends with a short conclusion (§8).

2. A definition of *antipassive construction* as a strategy

Since the 1970s, antipassive voice constructions have been defined in a way that is analogous to passive constructions. In the first article that uses the term, it is characterized as follows:

“I have termed this *-ki-* form the ANTIPASSIVE construction, playing upon its inverse equivalence to a passive of accusative languages, because the sense is clearly equivalent to a transitive, though the form is intransitive, with the grammatical function of the remaining noun phrase reversed (ergator becomes non-ergator).” (Silverstein 1972: 395).

We can thus say that an antipassive is the mirror image of a passive: While the A-argument is downgraded in passives, the P-argument is downgraded in antipassives (see also §4 below for more on the mirror-image view). I propose the two definitions in (3a-b), which are based on the notion of an *alternation* (i.e. a pair of sister valency constructions), and more specifically an *asymmetric voice alternation* (an alternation with coding on one of the two alternant verbs).

(3) a. **antipassive voice alternation**

An antipassive voice alternation is an asymmetric voice alternation in which the uncoded alternant is transitive (with A- and P-arguments), and the coded alternant is intransitive, with the basic P downgraded, and the basic A corresponding to S.

b. **antipassive voice construction**

An antipassive voice construction is the coded alternant in an antipassive voice alternation.

Thus, the notion of an antipassive voice construction presupposes the notion of an antipassive voice alternation.

Downgrading is defined here as a cover term for demotion and suppression, and antipassive constructions can be subclassified along this parameter: Some antipassives are P-demoting (with the argument corresponding to the basic P marked by an oblique flag), while others are P-suppressing (with the basic P eliminated from the valency).¹ Two further examples of antipassives are given in (4) (with an dative flag on the demoted antipassive patient in 4b) and (5) (where the patient is suppressed, i.e. cannot be expressed at all in 5b).

¹ “Downgrading” is used with various senses in the literature, similarly to “demotion” (see §5 for more discussion). I use it in a narrow sense here, as a cover term for demotion (i.e. oblique-marking) and suppression (non-expression).

(4) Nyawaygi (Pama-Nyungan; Dixon 1983: 496)

- a. *ŋin-da yagu bu:ga*
 you-ERG water.ABS drink
 ‘You drink some water!’
- b. *ŋin-ba bu:g-iga yagu-gu*
 you-ABS drink-ANTP water-DAT
 ‘You drink some water!’

(5) Russian (Malchukov 2017: 7)

- a. *Sobaka kusaet mal’čik-a.*
 dog.NOM bites boy-ACC
 ‘The dog bites the boy.’
- b. *Sobaka kusaet-sja.*
 dog.NOM bite-ANTP
 ‘The dog bites.’

The distinction between P-demoting and P-suppressing antipassives is paralleled in passive constructions, which may be A-demoting (as in English, where an oblique agent phrase is allowed), or A-suppressing.²

The definition in (3) specifies that the antipassive construction is intransitive (with an S-argument), while the uncoded alternant is transitive (with an A-argument and a P-argument). This is fully in line with most definitions in the literature (e.g. Dixon 1994: 146; Polinsky 2017: 309; Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich 2021: 2; Seržant et al. 2021: 970; Creissels 2024: 428), but what exactly is meant by the term *transitive*? In the literature, this is not always clear, but here I follow the definition of Lazard (2002) and Haspelmath (2011), where the transitive construction of a language is the argument-coding construction that it most often uses with effective-action verbs like ‘break’ and ‘kill’. When some other verb (basic or voice-coded) has the same argument-coding pattern as these two verbs, it is considered transitive.

Some authors work with a notion of “semantic transitivity” (e.g. Polinsky 2017: 310; Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich 2021: 3; Creissels 2024: §3.1.1), but it is best to use the terms *transitive*, *passive* and *antipassive* for kinds of (formally defined) strategies, and not for the functions (or functionally defined constructions) that they express (see Haspelmath 2025 on construction-functions and construction-strategies, following a distinction made by Croft 2016; 2022). Transitive, passive and antipassive constructions serve to express various kinds of agent-patient constructions, and S, A and P are argument types that serve to express agents, patients and other semantic participant roles.³

Following Haspelmath (2026a), we can offer the notation in (6) to describe the antipassive alternation, as well as the parallel notation in (7) for the passive. A voice alternation such as antipassive is a pair of two related valency patterns, generally an uncoded and a coded one (these are two strategies for expressing roughly the same content). There are two event participants X and Y (agent and patient), which correspond

² An alternative term for a P-suppressing voice construction is *deobjective* (Haspelmath 1990: 34), and an alternative term for a P-demoting voice construction in an accusative-alignment context is *deaccusative* (Geniušienė 1987: 256).

³ They are not “generalized semantic roles”, but comparative concepts for syntactic functions. Thus, S, A and P as understood here are rather different from Croft’s (2001: Ch. 8) and Bickel’s (2011) notions of S, A and P.

to A and P in the uncoded valency pattern, and to S and an oblique (or no) argument in the coded valency pattern.⁴

- (6) antipassive $\langle V, A_X, P_Y \rangle$
 $\approx \langle V\text{-ANTP}, S_X, \{\text{obl}\}_Y \rangle$ ‘X acts (on Y)’
- (7) passive $\langle V, A_X, P_Y \rangle$
 $\approx \langle V\text{-PASS}, \{\text{obl}\}_X, S_Y \rangle$ ‘(X) acts on Y’

The ad hoc notation for downgrading with curly braces (“{obl}”) is meant to say that the argument can be suppressed (necessarily absent) or demoted (to oblique). When the argument is demoted, it is still part of the antipassive valency pattern, and the construction is not “valency-reducing”.⁵

The antipassive strategy crucially makes use of an antipassive marker, because if there were no such marker, there would be no voice construction, as *voice* has always been associated with verbal marking (since traditional Latin grammar, and in typological linguistics since Mel’čuk & Xolodovič 1970; see Kulikov 2011).⁶ Moreover, without a marker, there would be no clear asymmetry between the two alternating constructions, and it would not be possible to treat one of them as “basic”, or to use quasi-processual terms such as “demotion” and “suppression”.

As antipassive constructions are types of constructions, they may be productive or unproductive (see Haspelmath 2023: §1 on (un)productive constructions). Traditionally, voice constructions have been regarded as part of the inflectional system, and inflection is usually productive (Comrie et al. (2021: 516) include productivity as one of the defining criteria).⁷ However, on the broader definition of *voice* (as in note 6), all voices (including passives and antipassives) may be unproductive and more like derivational affixes. In line with this view, the more recent literature has pointed to many cases of lexically restricted and unproductive antipassives (e.g. Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich 2021: §6; Seržant et al. 2021: §4.1).

⁴ The symbol “ $\approx$ ” is intended to link two sister constructions together. Note that the constructional view presented here is neutral between a “syntactic” and a “lexical(ist)” view that have sometimes been contrasted (e.g. Polinsky 2017: §13.4). Constructions have the same properties in “syntax”, “morphology”, and “lexicon”, and the “lexicon-grammar” contrast is not well-motivated (Haspelmath 2023: §6).

⁵ The oblique argument that corresponds to the P in the transitive construction is not an “adjunct” (cf. Song 2018: 379), and the construction is not “monovalent” when it includes a peripheral/oblique argument (cf. Zúñiga & Kittilä 2019: 103). The attribute “valency-reducing” (or “valency-decreasing”) is appropriate only for P-suppressing antipassives.

⁶ The term *voice* has often been used in an unclear way in the literature, and it is only since Zúñiga & Kittilä (2019) and Creissels (2024) that it has been established in the sense of “verbally coded construction in a valency (or diathesis) alternation” (it seems that Kulikov 2011 was influential in this regard). Causative and applicative constructions are thus also voice constructions. The earlier use of *voice* as an “inflectional category” is still visible in formulations such as “*the* antipassive involves morphological marking on the verb” (Polinsky 2026), which are similar to formulations such as “*the* perfect involves prefixing of the verb” (one would hardly say “*the* causative involves suffixing of the verb”, as *causative* is not a traditional inflectional category; instead, one talks about “causative constructions”).

⁷ Another recent paper implying that antipassives are necessarily productive is Polinsky (2026):

“For the purposes of the discussion here, the crucial difference is in productivity and semantic constraints on the participating verbs. While antipassives are a systematic part of the verbal alternation system of the languages that have them, the conative alternation in English is lexically restricted to certain verb classes, primarily verbs of contact (‘hit’, ‘kick’, ‘push’) and ingestion (‘eat’, ‘drink’).”

But this is not in line with most of the recent literature on antipassives.

3. Three potential antipassive universals

On the basis of the cross-linguistically viable definition of *antipassive* in §2, we can now consider three potential universals involving antipassive constructions. If we want to gain a general understanding of antipassives, rather than merely an understanding of language-particular constructions, we need to consider universals. The universals that I present as hypotheses here are listed in (8)-(10). All three are implicational universals, though only Universal 3 has an “if...then” structure. In the formulations of Universal 1 and 2, “preferentially” is intended as an abbreviatory device (i.e. if they occur in other contexts, they also occur in this context, but not vice versa).

(8) Universal 1: **Antipassive non-specificity**

P-demoting antipassives preferentially occur with indefinite and/or non-specific patient arguments.

(9) Universal 2: **Antipassive atelicity**

Antipassives preferentially occur with atelic and/or imperfective aspectual reference.

(10) Universal 3: **Secondary pivot-creating antipassives**

If a language has an antipassive construction that is required for some pivot constructions, the antipassive also occurs outside of these pivot constructions.

These universals are well-known from the literature on antipassives (e.g. Cooreman 1994; Polinsky 2017; Heaton 2020; Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich 2021), though they have not often been formulated in these particular ways. Most general works on antipassives present the formal patterns as well as common functions of antipassives without emphasizing implicational patterns or predictions. For example, Murasugi (2020: 277) briefly characterizes their functions as follows:

“The main functions [of antipassives] discussed in the literature are related to semantic properties such as the indefiniteness or low identifiability of the object and imperfective aspect of the predicate, or to syntactic functions such as the realignment of the subject from transitive to intransitive, and topic chaining.”

In the present paper, by contrast, I stress the advantages of formulations in terms of universals, as they potentially tell us something about Human Language in general, and they are (at least in principle) falsifiable hypotheses. Formulations such as Murasugi’s have a more anecdotal character, and their purpose is not fully clear. They seem to describe informally what has been observed in a range of languages, rather than advance predictive hypotheses.

I do not provide evidence for the universals in this paper, but state them as hypotheses which are consistent with the literature and which are plausibly true. For Universal 1 (Antipassive non-specificity), one can cite the following passages from the literature:

(11)a. Cooreman (1994: 52)

“Probably the most common use of the antipassive in the world’s ergative languages is the so-called Indefinite antipassive (see also Heath 1976). In this type of construction, the O is often deleted because it is unimportant in the discourse, indefinite, unknown, or obvious (in the sense that a generic class of items can be filled in, as in fishing for fish).”

- b. Vigus (2018: 343)
“Low individuation, low topicality, or a lack of focus on P is the most common function ascribed to antipassive constructions.”
- c. Murasugi (2020: 277)
“One of the most common correlates with the use of the antipassive is the low degree of identifiability of the object (Cooreman 1994). Objects with low identifiability have been characterized in a number of ways, including indefinite, non-referential, nonspecific, generic, unknown, and undisclosed; essentially, their identity is not considered an important part of the discourse.”

Vigus (2018) formulates the generalization in terms of “individuation”, a gradient composite parameter, but this seems too broad. While antipassive patient arguments are often required to be indefinite or non-specific, they are not commonly required to be inanimate, or non-singular, or non-count, so they are not general markers of lack of individuation.⁸

For Universal 2 (Antipassive atelicity), one can cite the following:

- (12)a. Cooreman (1994: 57)
“In many languages the antipassive differs from the ergative rendition of the same proposition in terms of aspect, i.e. the event or state-of-affairs is described as incomplete, or non-punctual. The antipassive is likely to describe an activity without a perceptible onset or conclusion.”
- b. Polinsky (2017: 315)
“Antipassives often have special aspectual meaning: inchoative, inceptive, durative, progressive, imperfective, or even iterative.”
- c. Creissels (2024: 434)
“In many languages, antipassivization implies reference to habitual rather than specific events, and the expression of the participant that would be encoded as P in the transitive construction, if possible at all, is conditioned by a low degree of referentiality. These tendencies have been repeatedly pointed out in the literature on antipassive.”

Most subsequent papers refer to Cooreman (1994), and the most important later study is Vigus (2018), which arrives at similar conclusions (though Vigus does not use the same definition as is used here, so that the results are not directly comparable). Universal 2 is formulated by Polinsky (2017) as an implicational universal (something that is done rarely in the literature on antipassives):

- (13) “If an antipassive construction can have a perfective (telic) interpretation, it must also have an imperfective (non-telic) interpretation.” (Polinsky 2017: 316)

⁸ Another factor that is sometimes mentioned in discussions of antipassive constructions is affectedness: Antipassives are sometimes said to express a less affected patient than the corresponding non-antipassive construction. I do not discuss this here, because such constructions tend to involve a clear change in semantic content, going beyond what one typically finds in passive constructions. But of course, these constructions are closely related to antipassives.

The literature on antipassive constructions has often emphasized the pivot-creating role of antipassives, which is relevant to Universal 3. In a number of languages an antipassive construction must be used for relativizing or questioning the agent or other related purposes. For example, in Inuktitut as described by Johns (1992), the antipassive construction is required for relativizing the agent argument, as seen in the contrast between (14b) and (14c).

(14) Inuktitut (Johns 1992: 61, 72)

- a. *Anguti-up nanuq kapi-ja-a.*
man-ERG bear.ABS stab-PTCP-3SG>3SG
'The man stabbed the bear.'
- b. **Anguti(-up) nanuq kapi-ja-a ani-juq.*
man(-ERG) [bear.ABS stab-PTCP-3SG] leave-PTCP.3SG
(‘The man who stabbed the bear left.’)
- c. *Anguti nanur-mik kapi-si-juq ani-juq.*
man.ABS [bear-MOD stab-ANTP-PTCP.3SG] leave-PTCP.3SG
'The man who stabbed the bear left.'

Universal 3 about pivot-creating antipassives has been formulated as an implicational universal in two earlier papers (again with Cooreman being the first author to state the generalization clearly).

(15) a. Cooreman (1994: 75)

“to my knowledge, there is no language which has a structural antipassive without there being one operating on semantic/pragmatic grounds. In contrast, the opposite is quite common, i.e. many languages have semantic/pragmatic antipassives unaccompanied by a structural antipassive.”

b. Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich (2021: 23)

“if a language has the syntactically motivated antipassive construction, it seems also to use the antipassive construction for semantic and/or discourse-pragmatic functions. ... The reverse situation is not necessarily true: the presence of a semantically and discourse pragmatically motivated antipassive construction does not imply that a language will also have the antipassive construction used for the syntactic reasons.”

Pivot-creating antipassives were prominent in the early phases of research on antipassives (in languages such as Dyirbal, Chukchi, varieties of Inuktitut-Yupik, varieties of Mayan), but it seems that they are far rarer than other kinds of antipassives (Heaton 2020: §3.3).

4. Antipassive as the mirror-image of passive

As I noted in §2 above, the definition given in the present paper presents antipassive constructions as an exact mirror-image of passive constructions. The following definitions of passive voice alternations and constructions were proposed in my earlier work (Haspelmath 2026b):

(3') a. **passive voice alternation**

A passive voice alternation is an asymmetric voice alternation in which the uncoded alternant is transitive (with A- and P-arguments), and the coded alternant is intransitive, with the basic A downgraded, and the basic P corresponding to S.

b. **passive voice construction**

A passive voice construction is the coded alternant in a passive voice alternation.

It should be noted that these definitions do not make use of a notion of “subject”, in contrast with much other work in syntax that continues to use this concept. For example, Polinsky (2026) characterizes the relationship between passives and antipassives as follows:

“The passive canonically “demotes” the logical subject (agent), either removing it entirely or expressing it as an oblique phrase (as in English “by-phrases”), while promoting the logical object (patient, undergoer) to subject position. In contrast, the antipassive is understood as an operation that demotes or omits the logical object while maintaining the prominence of the logical subject.” (Polinsky 2026)

Here the passive is characterized as “promoting” the P to S, while the antipassive “maintains” the A as “logical subject”. In the definition of the present paper, by contrast, the A is advanced to S in an antipassive in exactly the same way as the P is advanced to S in a passive.⁹ There does not seem to be any reason to posit an asymmetry between passives and antipassives, other than perhaps the inclination to continue to use the traditional term “subject”.

However, there may be one way in which antipassives do not behave quite as the mirror-image of passives: While the oblique passive agent seems to be always optional, the demoted patient of an antipassive is sometimes obligatory.¹⁰ An example is the French construction illustrated in (16a-b), where the oblique object argument in the antipassive construction cannot be omitted from (16b).

(16) French (Janic 2016: 205)

- a. *Les étudiants attaquent les révisions.*
the students start the revisions
'The students start the revisions.'
- b. *Les étudiants s'attaquent aux révisions.*
the students ANTP start to.the revisions
'The students start (with) the revisions.'

But it must be admitted that it could be that there are some languages in which the oblique passive agent is obligatory. Although such passives have not been highlighted in the literature, they may simply have been overlooked, so I do not regard this as a very robust asymmetry.

⁹ And just as the antipassive A-to-S change can be “vacuous” (i.e. not leading to a case change) in an accusative-alignment construction, where A/S are nominative-coded, the passive P-to-S change can be “vacuous” in an ergative-alignment construction, where P/S are absolutive-coded.

¹⁰ There are also some other ways, as Katarzyna Janic (p.c.) reminds me. Lazard (1998: 229) and Creissels (2006: 88) have some relevant discussion.

Another potential asymmetry between antipassives and passives was recently noted by Polinsky (2026), who claims that passive agent arguments are still “syntactically projected” even when they are unexpressed, while antipassive patient arguments may be completely absent. For example, she notes that a Kaqchikel antipassive patient argument that is unexpressed cannot be interpreted anaphorically, as illustrated in (17).

- (17) Kaqchikel (antipassive; Polinsky 2026, ex. (9b))
Ja ri ixoq-i' y-e-kem-on.
 FOC DET woman-PL IC MPL-3PL.ABS-weave-ANTP
 ‘The women are engaged in weaving.’ (not: ‘...are weaving it.’)

This does seem to be a general property of antipassives: When a patient argument is not expressed, it is interpreted indefinitely, not anaphorically (in line with Universal 1). However, is this so different from passive agents? It seems that these are generally interpreted indefinitely rather than anaphorically, too. Consider the English example in (18).

- (18) *A policeman filmed a violent soccer fan, who was arrested immediately.*

This would typically be understood as saying that the fan was arrested by someone else, not by the policeman who filmed him.¹¹

5. More on the definition of *antipassive construction*

The definition proposed in §2 has two crucial properties: (i) it is a sharp definition, and (ii) it can be applied to all languages using the same criteria. These are the most important criteria for all types of comparative-concept definitions in linguistics. Some authors offer prototype-based definitions, e.g. Zúñiga & Kittilä (2019: 103), as well as Polinsky (2026):

“In its prototypical form, the antipassive involves morphological marking on the verb, often through dedicated antipassive morphology, while the erstwhile patient (i.e., affected object) either becomes an oblique argument (e.g., a prepositional phrase) or is completely omitted from the clause.” (Polinsky 2026)

But non-sharp definitions like this one do not allow us to formulate testable hypotheses such as those in §3, and prototype-based definitions can be extended in an almost limitless way, thus leading to a very blurred picture.

Definitions of comparative-concept terms must be applicable to all languages in the same way, in order to avoid cherry-picking of criteria. If different criteria are used, it is quite likely that the phenomena are incommensurable, because we cannot assume that “antipassive” is an innate category of the language blueprint. For this reason, it is important to use clearly defined comparative concepts for syntactic functions such as S, A and P (Haspelmath 2011; Creissels 2024: §1.3.3), rather than concepts such as “(logical) object”, “external/internal argument” which are not defined in a way that is clearly operationalized. Some authors seem to think that one can use different criteria for different languages, e.g. Polinsky (2017: 309), who mentions a Ukrainian antipassive construction and says that the patient object “fails various direct-object diagnostics; for

¹¹ It is true that omitted passive agents can occasionally be understood as definite/anaphoric, as in the sentence *Her latest book was written in 2015* (Chung 2025: 63), but such sentences sound unusual.

example, it cannot bind depictives or float quantifiers”. But these “diagnostics” do not uniformly pick out “direct objects” across languages because not all languages have such constructions, and they are not always excluded from oblique-marked arguments.¹²

Vigus (2018: 343) discusses “structural criteria” (i.e. criteria for defining antipassive as a strategy rather than as a functionally defined construction) and correctly observes:

“It is not clear why a particular combination of structural criteria should be considered as the only “true” type of antipassive. There also appears to be no principled way of deciding which criteria to select as definitional.”

Choosing a definition of a comparative-concept term is a methodological decision, and the choice need not be “principled”. Apart from sharpness and uniform applicability, a requirement for a definition is that it should be clear and not too long, and it should be easy to remember. The definition given in (3) is easy to remember also because it is parallel to the definition of *passive*, thus making the term *anti-passive* quite transparent.

The definition is fairly widely accepted, though a number of authors include constructions lacking verbal marking (see Heaton 2020: 134-135). But as has been noted by Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich (2021: 15) (among others), a definition that does not require an antipassive marker would presumably include P-omission constructions such as *Speed kills*, which are extremely widespread in the world’s languages. Such a definition would clearly be too broad. It is true, of course, that there are many antipassive-like constructions that one would like to bring into in the broader picture, including the English conative alternation (e.g. *shoot the bear/shoot at the bear*), but a definition must primarily be clear and sharp. For a broader picture, one could use a different term, such as “P-backgrounding construction” (e.g. Seržant et al. 2021).

Some authors also include constructions where the patient argument is not oblique-marked but does not look like an ordinary P-argument either. For example, Polinsky (2017: 312) cites the examples in (19) from Maori, where (19b) is an “antipassive” in her classification, because the patient argument (‘tickets for the children’) is not accusative-flagged (as it is in (19a)), but unflagged in an immediately postverbal position (“pseudo-incorporated”).¹³

(19) Maori

- a. *Ka hoko te matua i ngā tīkiti mo ngā tamariki.*
AOR buy DET parent ACC DET.PL ticket for DET.PL children
‘The parent buys (the) tickets for the children.’
- b. *Ka hoko tīkiti mo ngā tamariki te matua.*
AOR buy ticket for DET.PL children DET parent
‘The parent buys tickets for the children.’

As the patient argument is not oblique-flagged here, the construction in (19b) does not fall under the definition that I gave in (3), but Polinsky includes it because she works with

¹² Similarly, Chung (2025) says about Chamorro that “various sorts of evidence reveal that the external argument is the subject in examples (1) and (3) and the internal argument is the subject in (2)”, referring to her earlier work. The notion of Chamorro Subject is surely well-motivated, but this is a language-particular notion, which need not be commensurable with what is called “Subject” in other languages.

¹³ Similarly, Creissels (2024: §10.2.3) includes cases with “incorporated P” in his characterization of antipassivization.

a broader notion of “demotion”: Any lowering of a nominal phrase on the “hierarchy of grammatical roles” counts as demotion:

(20) subject > object > non-core argument > non-argument

It is true that in the original Relational Grammar sense, “demotion” seems to have had a meaning of this kind (Blake 1990: 18-20; see also Creissels 2024: 321), but “non-argument” was never well-defined, and changes from subject to object were always more likely to be called “raising”. In the general typological literature, “demotion” usually refers to changes from a core argument to an oblique argument (Creissels 2024 uses the new term *denucleativization*).¹⁴

Another issue that has sometimes come up in the literature is how to treat Philippine-type languages with symmetrical-voice systems, such as Tagalog. Some authors such as Payne (1982) and Aldridge (2012) have treated undergoer-voice (UV) constructions such as (21a) as basic ergative constructions, and actor-voice (AV) constructions such as (21b) as antipassive constructions.

(21) Tagalog (Aldridge 2012: 192-193)

- a. *B<in>ili ng babae ang isda.*
 <UV>buy ERG woman ABS fish
 ‘The woman bought the fish.’
- b. *B<um>ili ang babae ng isda.*
 <AV>buy ABS woman OBL fish
 ‘The woman bought a fish.’

Other authors such as Kroeger (1993) and Chen (2017) have argued that the patient in actor-voice constructions should not be treated as oblique, and that we are dealing with accusative-alignment constructions, not ergative alignment.

In contrast to both these views, I would say that Tagalog does not have a transitive agent-patient strategy at all, because in order to identify an A and a P, we need to identify a single major construction for expressing agent and patient, and it appears that both the actor-voice and the patient-voice constructions are “major” (in the sense that neither is clearly much less common). In a language like English, we say that a construction such as *The fish was bought by the woman* is not a transitive construction because this construction is much less frequent than *The woman bought the fish*.¹⁵ Thus, as Tagalog and other Philippine-type languages have two major agent-patient constructions, they cannot be fitted into the typology of transitive coding. Terms such as *transitive*, *passive* and *antipassive* are terms for strategies, and a language may lack all these strategies (see also Haspelmath 2025).

In general, passives and antipassives are much rarer than the corresponding uncoded constructions, accounting for much less than a third of the total number of agent-patient

¹⁴ And an oblique argument is always marked by a flag other than accusative or ergative by definition. Unflagged nominals are not normally called *oblique*. (Spreng (2010: 561) considers the option that a non-agreeing unflagged object in Hindi might be “oblique”, but this is excluded on the definition of *oblique* that I use here. It appears that Spreng has some other notion in mind, perhaps related to Polinsky’s “non-argument”).

¹⁵ Similarly, Janic & Hemmings (2021: 208) define accusative alignment as a situation where the “A-prominent construction [=construction where the agent is treated like the intransitive S] is functionally unmarked”, i.e. more frequent (among other things). See also Comrie (1981: §2.2) for a similar view.

constructions (e.g. Shibatani 1985 for passives; Seržant et al. 2021 for antipassive constructions). If they were about as frequent as (or even more frequent than) the other construction, one would not be able to say that there is a single agent-patient construction. Occasionally, it has been reported that “passive” constructions occur 40% of the time or more, but such languages should not be said to have transitive (and thus passive) constructions. For “antipassives”, Carrier (2017) reports on some varieties of Inuktitut where “antipassives” occur 50% of the time or more (see also Janic & Hemmings 2021), and again, the “non-antipassives” would not count as transitive according to the current terminological conventions (so that the constructions do not count as passive or non-antipassive in a comparative perspective).

Finally, there is another point of variation in the definitions in the literature. In Dixon’s (1994: 146) definition, the oblique patient nominal is said to be omissible, but he also says that “there is always the option of including it” (similarly in Song 2018: 379).¹⁶ This differs from the definition in (3), where P-suppressing (or deobjective) antipassives are included, in line with general practice. For example, Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich (2021: 2) say that in an antipassive,

“the patient-like (P) argument in the transitive construction is either encoded as an oblique or left unexpressed in the corresponding antipassive construction.”

In the present context, where the parallels between antipassives and passives are highlighted, a relevant consideration is that passive agents are suppressed in many languages. Thus, to make the definitions of passives and antipassives parallel, we allow P-suppressing antipassives as well. This point is important, because “the most frequent marked antipassive constructions do not allow the patient to be overtly expressed at all”, as noted by Heaton (2020: 140). P-suppressing antipassives are thus more common, even though P-demoting antipassives are the textbook example (and were also given first in this paper; see 1b and 4b).

The definition of antipassive adopted here is thus broader than Dixon’s, but narrower than other characterizations which treat antipassives in functional terms rather than as strategies (e.g. Vigus 2018; Croft 2022: §8.4). Such broader definitions are motivated by the wish to include other construction types that have similar functions (P-omission, “pseudo-incorporation”, and so on), and eventually these should of course be part of the bigger picture (as mentioned earlier). But the terms *passive* and *antipassive* have originally been used for very specific kinds of strategies and should continue to have precise definitions as strategies, so that one can formulate testable hypotheses about their properties (see also Haspelmath 2026c on the definition of passive as a strategy type, rather than as a functionally defined construction type).

6. Possible explanations of the universals

As the ultimate goal of general-theoretical linguistics is to understand the nature of Human Language, we are of course interested in explaining the universals that were discovered. This is still more challenging than comparing grammatical patterns and finding cross-linguistic generalizations, and most explanations are quite uncertain. For completeness, I discuss possible explanations of the universals of §3 in this section. The

¹⁶ Lehmann (2015: 1586) also makes the option of including an oblique patient argument a required part of the definition. For the P-suppressing construction, he uses the special term *introversion* (corresponding to *deobjective* in Haspelmath 1990).

discussion is deliberately short and separated from the statement of universals here, because it is an important methodological point that cross-linguistic comparison and explanation of generalizations are distinct enterprises.¹⁷ Universals 1-3 are repeated here for convenience.

(8) Universal 1: **Antipassive non-specificity**

P-demoting antipassives preferentially occur with indefinite and/or non-specific patient arguments.

(9) Universal 2: **Antipassive atelicity**

Antipassives preferentially occur with atelic and/or imperfective aspectual reference.

(10) Universal 3: **Secondary pivot-creating antipassives**

If a language has an antipassive construction that is required for some pivot constructions, the antipassive also occurs outside of these pivot constructions.

The first two universals have sometimes been explained in the literature with respect to the notion of “reduced transitivity”. It is often said that it is characteristic of transitive clauses that they tend to have a definite and/or specific patient nominal, as well as perfective aspect. Thus, it does not seem to be an accident that the first two properties go together, and Cooreman (1994: 51) proposes that semantic-pragmatic antipassives are “best described as indicating a certain degree of difficulty with which an effect stemming from an activity by [the agent] on an identifiable [patient] can be recognized.” But this formulation is so general and abstract that it is difficult to recognize that it is intended to generalize over the non-specificity and the atelicity universals. Why the two should go together is not very clear (but see also Malchukov 2006 for related discussion).

For indefiniteness and non-specificity, one might point to the opposite pattern with passives, where patient arguments tend to be topical, so that we observe the expected mirror-image pattern. And indeed, Givón (1994: 8-9) says that passive and antipassive both show a strong asymmetry with respect to topicality, as summarized in (22).

(22)	RELATIVE TOPICALITY
passive:	agent << patient
antipassive:	agent >> patient

In both cases, there is a topicality asymmetry, and while the passive shows an “extremely non-topical agent”, the antipassive is characterized by an “extremely non-topical patient”. But whereas patient topicality is unexpected (thus helping explain the asymmetric coding of passive verbs; Haspelmath 2021: §10.1), patient non-topicality is expected (because patients tend to be focal information), so why should there be extra marking on the verb? The complete absence of a patient argument (as the limiting case of “extreme non-topicality”) does seem to be generally unexpected by hearers and hence in need of verbal coding. But why indefinite and non-specific overt patients should also be associated with special verbal marking is not clear to me.

For atelicity and imperfectivity, authors such as Spreng (2010) and Heaton (2020: §3.2) have observed that some languages have “ergativity splits” that exhibit similarities: imperfective clauses with nominative agents and accusative/oblique patients, contrasting

¹⁷ In generative grammar, descriptive/analytical concepts, concepts for comparison, and explanations of universals often make reference to the same explanatory idea (an innate blueprint for grammar, also called UG). In the current approach, description/analysis, comparison, and explanation are all separate.

with perfective clauses with ergative agents and absolutive patients. These patterns do not seem to be accidental, but what explains them? Why should passive/ergative clauses be associated with telic/perfective aspectuality, while antipassive/accusative clauses are associated with atelic/imperfective aspectuality?

Here Comrie (1981) might offer some insights: He notes that perfect aspect expresses a resulting state, and perfective aspect often develops from it. The results of a transitive event are most salient on the patient, so that we can expect perfects (and perfectives) to be “patient-oriented”. Conversely, prospective aspect focuses on a state of the agent (e.g. *The rock is going to hit Bill*, which is about a state of the rock), so that we can expect prospectives (and to some extent also imperfectives) to be “agent-oriented”. Since perfect aspect repeatedly gives rise to ergative alignment, and imperfective aspect gives rise to accusative alignment (see Anderson 2016), we may also have an explanation of the associations with alignment types. However, it is a very tentative explanation that has not been picked up in the literature on antipassives, as far as I am aware.

As for Universal 3, Cooreman (1994: §5) offered the explanation that “structural antipassives” generally derive from “semantic-pragmatic antipassives”. Her discussion is very interesting and still worth reading, but the explanation is quite speculative. We really do not know.

Thus, the explanations that can be offered for the three universals are quite tentative and highly uncertain. The main reason for discussing them here is to emphasize the need to explain the universals (if they turn out to be true): If a fairly specific phenomenon is general across languages, it cannot be accidental and thus may yield valuable insights about the nature of Human Language. Universals and their explanations are the ultimate aim of general-comparative linguistics.

7. Describing antipassive(-like) constructions: In the language’s own terms

Different languages have different structural systems, for example different syllable structures (e.g. Blevins 1995), different case systems (e.g. Blake 2001), and so on, as has been discussed in structural linguistics since the middle of the last century. A representative quote is the following:

“None of [the concepts of grammar], as used till now, is susceptible of general definition: genitive, perfect, subjunctive, and passive are quite different things in one language, Latin for example, from what they are in another, say Greek. The same is true, without any exception, of the remaining concepts of conventional linguistics.”
(Hjelmslev 1961: 12)

That different languages have different syntactic categories has been widely accepted in typological linguistics in recent decades, especially through work by Dryer (e.g. 1997) and Croft (e.g. 2009). The cross-linguistic divergence of categories means that we cannot normally use the building blocks of one language to describe another language. Thus, each language must be described in its own terms (Boas 1911; Haspelmath 2020), rather than with general cross-linguistic categories.

If each language is described with its own grammatical concepts, this means that language describers are not dependent on general linguists for their analyses. If they find a phenomenon that looks unfamiliar, they can give it a completely new name. Consider the constructions in (23a) and (23b) from Nez Perce. In the first construction, the agent

nominal is ergative-marked and the patient nominal is accusative-marked, while in the second construction, there is no case marking.

(23) Nez Perce (Sahaptian; Rude 1986: 126; 129)

- a. *Háama-nm pée-'wi-ye' wewúkiye-ne.*
 man-ERG 3.TR-shoot-ASP elk-ACC
 'The man shot the elk.'
- b. *Páaxloo ha'áyat hi-ḡ'ni-siix qé'mes.*
 five women 3.NOM-dig-ASP camas
 'Five women are digging camas (*Camassia quamash*).'

Rude (1986: 129) calls the second construction “antipassive”, while Deal (2010: 75) initially calls them *caseless clauses*, though she also uses the term “antipassive”. But she notes:

“The Nez Perce antipassive differs from a classical antipassive construction in not showing oblique case on the object (which I take to be a low-level effect) and in not showing an antipassive morpheme in the verb.” (Deal 2010: 84)

But what is the point of using the term *antipassive* here if the construction does not fall under the definition of antipassive? For the purposes of describing or analyzing Nez Perce, it is sufficient to have the term *caseless (agent-patient) clause*, though one can of course note that it is antipassive-like in that the object nominal is indefinite.

For language-particular phenomena, one can always coin a new term (such as *Caseless Clause*), and in fact, it is better to use upper case for language-particular grammatical terms, because each construction has specific features anyway. Saying that a particular construction “is an antipassive construction” is a typological classification, not an analysis or description.¹⁸

Many languages have phenomena that are similar to phenomena in other languages but do not seem to fall under any general concept known from other languages. For example, several Dagestanian languages can express agent-patient events by an ergative construction (with an ergative and an absolutive argument) or alternatively by a “bi-absolutive” construction (with two absolutive-marked arguments), as illustrated by (24a-b) from Archi (Forker 2012: 78).

(24) Archi

- a. *Buwa-mu xx^walli barši b-i.*
 mother-ERG bread.ABS make G3-be
 'Mother is baking the bread.'
- b. *Buwa xx^walli barši d-i.*
 mother.ABS bread.ABS make G2-be
 'Mother is baking the bread.'

¹⁸ For this reason, it is not really appropriate to talk about “analyzing a phenomenon in a language L as X”, where X is a general term. One can describe (and possibly name) a construction (or other phenomenon), but not describe it as instantiating a general construction type.

Again, one could be tempted to say that the biabsolutive is like an antipassive (cf. Comrie et al. 2021: 543), but it does not fall under the definition that I gave in (3). It does not fall under any other well-known construction or strategy type either, but this is not a problem: Each language may have its own strategies, and it is not a problem for description or analysis if a pattern is not very similar to patterns known from other languages.

Finally, some languages have constructions with variants of which only one counts as antipassive from a general perspective. For example, the Warrongo antipassive construction with the verbal suffix *-gali* may occur with a nominative/absolutive agent and dative patient (as in (25a), already seen in §1 above), or with nominative/absolutive agent and accusative patient (as in (25b); see also Heaton 2020: 136).

(25) Warrongo (Pama-Nyungan; Tsunoda 2011: 428; 484)

- a. *Bama-Ø gamo-wu yangga-gali-n.*
man-ABS water-DAT search-ANTP-NF
'The man looked for water.' (= (1b) above)
- b. *Yinda jarroja-Ø woda-gali-ya.*
you.NOM trousers-ACC take.off-ANTP-IMP
'Take off (your) trousers.'

From a Warrongo perspective, it is best to say that these two sentences represent variants of the same Antipassive construction. But from a general perspective, only (25a) is an antipassive construction. There is no contradiction here, because language-particular categories are defined in language-particular terms, while general-comparative concepts are defined in general terms.

8. Conclusion

There are many different kinds of constructions in the broad domain of patient-backgrounding constructions, and many terminological proposals and practices can be found in the literature. Heaton (2020) describes the findings of a study of over four hundred languages (Heaton 2017):

“The results were striking in terms of just how much variation there is in the data: Even though there were more than 100 different sets of features that describe different antipassive-like constructions, only 64 of these sets of features appeared twice or more in the data set. Therefore, many sets of features which describe a structure in a given language did not recur, highlighting the heterogeneity of this pool of constructions potentially lumped together under the antipassive label.” (Heaton 2020: 137-138)

Because of this heterogeneity, it is quite likely that the prominence of the term *antipassive* is due to an accident of the history of linguistics, not due to a special importance of the constructions that fall under this label.

More generally, there is no reason to think that one terminological system is necessarily better than others, but also no reason to think that terminological confusions will become fewer automatically as research on different languages advances. I make a very concrete proposal for a definition of *antipassive* in this paper, meant to be very simple and maximally similar to *passive*, with only one difference (P-downgrading

instead of A-downgrading). This definition has the advantage of simplicity, but whether it will yield more insights than other conceivable concepts in this domain is not clear.

General understanding in research on grammar usually results from identifying general or universal trends, and at least a few universals of antipassive constructions have been identified (discussed in §3 and §6). Thus, the term *antipassive* does have some usefulness, though other (broader, or narrower) concepts may ultimately prove even more conducive to deeper understanding.

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